

is second-best in a race of two! *FlightGear* is a comprehensive simulator that includes aircrafts that date back to the Wright brothers, as well as the latest jets.

The cockpits are very realistic, and the controls are standard. The 3D is well detailed, and when you run the game for the first time you will be surprised—for long, Open Source has been a synonym for amazingly functional software that aren't as pretty as their paid counterparts; but not this time!

As it should be with every simulator, *FlightGear* lets you customise everything with hundreds of different options: from the type of plane, the country, the starting airport, your entire flight plans, and even the time of flight.

Since *FlightGear* is Open Source software, it is not operating system specific, and can be installed on a Windows, Linux and even a Mac-based computer. The selection of scenery, or countries, is vast, and you will need to download the detailed scenery for the sector in which you wish to fly. On their Web site, *FlightGear* has broken up the entire map of the Earth into a grid of 36 x 18 equal sized segments, and you can download the scenery data for any particular segment by simply clicking on it.

Digit provided *FlightGear* and the entire scenery data for India in its October 2005 DVD, and you should look there for the installer. Those who don't have that issue, or want data for more locations, visit www.flightgear.org. Be warned; these downloads can be quite considerable in size. On an average, scenery data for each grid segment is anywhere from 30 MB to 90 MB in size. The download size for newer airplane models is small though—an average of 1 MB!

Overall, with great features such as autopilot, navigation assistance and an exhaustive aircraft list, *FlightGear* is a must-have for simulator geeks. Visit www.flightgear.org to find some great tutorials and hints for *FlightGear*.